

Describing Meaning – Week 11

Tense and Aspect

Using the following:

- S : **speech time**
- T : **topic/reference time**
- E : **eventuality time**
- $\subseteq$: Temporally includes
- $<$: Temporally precedes

For simple **eventive** clauses:

$$E \subseteq T$$

The simple with eventive predicates

- (a) For each sentence below, determine the relation between T and S and E .
- (1)
- Fiona rolled over.
 - Fiona will roll over.
 - Tomorrow Fiona will roll over.
 - Yesterday Tom wrote the essay.

The perfect with eventive predicates

- For each sentence below, determine the relation between T and S and E .
- (2)
 - Fiona ate her dinner.
 - Fiona has finished eating her dinner.
 - Fiona had finished eating her dinner.
 - Fiona will have finished eating her dinner.
- Based on these relations, determine the contribution of perfect aspect for eventive predicates.

The progressive with eventive predicates

1. For each sentence below, determine the relation between T and S and E .
 - (3)
 - a. Tweety flew.
 - b. Tweety was flying.
 - c. Tweety is flying.
 - d. Tweety will be flying.
2. Based on these relations, determine the contribution of progressive aspect for eventive predicates.

Statives

Here are some stative predicates in the simple aspect with various tenses.

- (4)
 - a. Sarah knew the answer.
 - b. Fiona loves Tom.
 - c. Valentina was in Dublin.
 - d. Johnathan will own a bicycle.
- (a) Do these behave like the simple eventive cases from Section 1?
 - (b) Propose a relation between E and T for simple statives.

Statives and the perfect

Continuative perfects

Compare:

- (5)
 - a. Omar has been sick for two days.
 - b. Sheila has worked in the library since December.
 - c. The door has been open for ten minutes.
- (a) In each case, does the state still hold at speech time?
 - (b) Does the same perfect relation you proposed for eventive predicates fit these cases straightforwardly?

The imperfective paradox

Compare:

- (6)
 - a. Tweety was flying to London.
 - b. Tweety flew to London.
 - c. Max was crossing the street when he was hit by a bus.
 - d. Max crossed the street.
- (a) Which of these are compatible with the endpoint not being reached?
- (b) Which of them strongly prefer a reading where the endpoint is reached?
- (c) Why does this show that the progressive cannot simply mean the same thing as the corresponding simple clause?
- (d) How does this connect to the difference between accomplishments and their progressive forms?

Progressive and states

Consider:

- (7)
 - a. #Jones is owning an old Jaguar.
 - b. We live in London.
 - c. We are living in London.
- (a) Why is (a) bad?
- (b) What extra meaning does the progressive seem to introduce in (c), compared with (b)?
- (c) What does this suggest about the interaction between the progressive and stative predicates?